



IN JANUARY, PRINCIPALS, HEAD EXAMINERS OF KENDRIYA VIDYALAYAS, NAVODAYA, TOP DELHI SCHOOLS TESTED SYSTEM

What CBSE ignored: Its own panel found glitches in dry run, said delay OSM by a year

After trial in Delhi in Jan 2026, two reports sent to Board, highlighted major problems, tech glitches, random increase, decrease in marks

Vidheesha Kuntamalla
New Delhi, June 2

- THE CBSE’s new On-Screen Marking (OSM) system needs at least a year’s trial and rectification before being implemented.
- The OSM system depends heavily on well-equipped evaluation centres and highly trained evaluators.
- Improved training is essential for fair, transparent, and error-free marking of answer scripts. This needs time to be done properly.
- The OSM system is glitchy, and it is unable to resolve these glitches speedily.

These are some of the problems with the digital evaluation system that were explicitly flagged to the CBSE by participants in an evaluation dry run carried out by the Board less than a month before this year’s Class 12 examinations began on February 17.

The CBSE pushed through the system anyway. Instead of paper booklets, examiners used computers to evaluate digitally scanned copies of answer scripts submitted by the examinees, which the CBSE put on a secure online platform.

Students started complaining about their marks almost

»CONTINUED ON PAGE 2

●THE EARLY WARNING

Glitches flagged during dry run

- Score increases by additional head examiners reportedly reflected as deductions.
- Marks showed on-screen didn’t always align with official marking.
- In some cases, marks for one sub-part of a question reflected.
- System reportedly allowed or forced 0.5-mark award not permitted under marking scheme.
- Evaluators reported that the platform would freeze.
- Evaluation progress reportedly not being saved automatically.
- Marks could reportedly be entered against blank pages, unattempted questions.



CBSE claims to have fixed

- ‘Save’ option added to evaluation interface.
- Mark deletion process simplified.
- Static IP issue fixed before actual evaluation.
- Marks’ display repositioned to avoid obscuring answers.
- AHE/HE review process revised to allow answer-book review irrespective of daily evaluation percentage.
- Server capacity enhanced to address internet speed.

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Rahul Singh: CBSE Chairman who failed board test

Board’s portal for re-evaluation faces cyberattacks

CBSE Chairman, Secretary moved out, OSM service procurement to be probed

Harikishan Sharma & Abhinaya Harigovind
New Delhi, June 2

WITH THE Central Board of Secondary Education (CBSE) under fire over glitches in the On-Screen Marking (OSM) system for its Class 12 board exam, the Centre Tuesday moved out CBSE Chairman Rahul Singh and Secretary Himanshu Gupta and named their replacements.

The government also set up a one-member committee to look into the procurement of services for the OSM system. To be chaired by S Radha Chauhan, Chairperson, Capacity Building Commission, it has been asked to submit its report

to the Department of Personnel and Training (DoPT) within a month.

The announcements came on the day official sources confirmed that the issue flagged in a May 31 post on X by Nisarga Adhikary — a 19-year-old ethical hacker, he had also posted a picture to indicate that he could access the scanned answer sheets — had been verified, resulting in the Board acknowledging “vulnerabilities” in the OSM portal.

“The vendor had a security audit certificate, and the Board didn’t do an audit of the vendor’s systems,” the sources said.

Lokhande Prashant Sitaram

»CONTINUED ON PAGE 2

Top court appoints high-powered panel to review Aravalli definition report

Jay Mazoomdaar
New Delhi, June 2

THE SUPREME Court on Tuesday constituted a High-Powered Committee (HPC) under Kanchan Devi, Director General, Indian Council of Forestry Research and Education (ICFRE), to obtain a “fair, impartial and independent” opinion and “resolve critical ambiguities” in the report on the definition of the Aravalli hills submitted last October by a panel headed by the Environment Secretary.

The HPC has been asked to submit its comprehensive report by August 31.

ICFRE is an autonomous council under the Ministry of Environment, Forest and Climate Change, and is registered as a society with the MoEF Minister as its President.

Kanchan Devi, a 1991-batch Indian Forest Service officer, reports to the ICFRE Board of Gov-

ernors headed by the Environment Secretary. The High Powered Committee will review the October 2025 report of the earlier Aravalli panel, which was chaired by the MoEF Secretary.

Other than Kanchan Devi who will be the ex-officio chairperson, the HPC announced on Tuesday has four members — Dr Subhash Ashutosh, former Director General of the Forest Survey of India; Dr Rajendra Kumar Sharma, former Director of the Geological Survey of India; Brij Mohan Singh Rathore, former Joint Secretary in the Environment Ministry; and Prof Ashok K Bhatnagar, former head of the Department of Botany at Delhi University.

The SC also named two special invitees — Prof Jagdish Krishnaswamy of the Indian Institute for Human Settlements, Bengaluru, and Prof Laxmikant Sharma of the Central University

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INDIAN EXPRESS UPSC IAS EDITION HD 03~06~2026 -:-FOR UPSC IAS ASPIRANTS:-

"AVOID POLITICAL & IRRELEVANT ARTICLES"

Please Try To Read This Completely in 40 Minutes If You Can't So Then You Have To Increase Your Efforts

All the topics of this UPSC IAS Edition are directly or indirectly important for the prelims & main examination.

There are some topics which can be coded in answer writing of other topics in the main exam.

AMID LPG IMPORT DISRUPTION

For larger PNG footprint, Govt looks at consumer-friendly centralised portal

Sukalp Sharma
New Delhi, June 2

MOVING TO push piped natural gas (PNG) connections amid the squeeze in supply of LPG owing to the crisis in West Asia, the government is actively considering a proposal to launch a national centralised portal for consumers to apply for PNG connections, *The Indian Express* has learnt.

The proposal, a senior official said, also involves putting gas grid maps online to ostensibly facilitate customer re-

E. EXPLAINED

Huge base, wide gap

LPG has a huge consumer base in households across the country: 33.3 crore domestic connections. Households with PNG connections are far fewer at about 1.6 crore. In the current scenario, priority sectors continue to get natural gas supplies.

quests and their ability to locate a pipeline near their premises. But there are potential security risks around placing natural gas pipeline layouts and maps in the public domain.

The proposal is being deliberated upon and there is no clear timeline yet on its implementation. The official said it could be announced over the next few days or weeks.

Currently, consumers are required to apply for a connection directly with the city gas distribution (CGD) entities

»CONTINUED ON PAGE 2

TALKS FOCUS WILL BE ON ENERGY, TRADE TIES

Venezuela's Rodriguez arrives today on India visit, to meet PM

Shubhajit Roy
New Delhi, June 2

ACTING PRESIDENT of Venezuela Delcy Rodriguez is coming to India for a five-day visit from June 3 to 7. The visit assumes significance as it comes five months after Venezuela President Nicolas Maduro was captured by the US forces on January 3, and Rodriguez, formerly Venezuela's Vice-President, was appointed the country's Acting President. Announcing the visit, the official spokesperson of the Ministry of External Affairs, Randhir Jaiswal, said Tuesday: "Acting President Rodriguez, who was earlier scheduled to visit India to participate in the International Big Cats Alliance summit on June 1 which has been deferred, will pay a working visit to India."

It is important to note that the MEA identified Rodriguez as the "Acting President", and not President of Venezuela — given the unusual transition of power after Maduro's capture. Many countries, including Russia, have criticised the US action and called it "illegal".

Rodriguez will be accompanied by several ministers, including the minister of foreign affairs, economy and finance, science and technology, communication and information and transportation.

She has visited India several times in the past in her capacity as the Foreign Minister of Venezuela in 2015, as also in her capacity as the country's Vice-President in 2019, 2023, 2024 and 2025. "This will be her sixth visit to India. So, she has had a long association with us," the MEA spokesperson said. During the visit, Acting President Rodriguez will hold bilateral discussions with Prime Minister Narendra Modi.

"The discussions will involve the full spectrum of India-Venezuela relations and involve and explore revenues for further co-operation in the areas of energy, trade, investment, pharmaceuticals, healthcare, transportation and renewable energy," the MEA spokesperson said.

India is an important partner of Venezuela in the areas of energy and investment. Indian public sector



This will be Venezuela Acting President Delcy Rodriguez's sixth visit to India. FILE

undertakings have made significant investment in Venezuela in the energy sector, and they are keen to explore more opportunities to further enhance their presence, the MEA spokesperson said.

India — specifically private sector refining giant Reliance Industries (RIL) — was a regular buyer of Venezuelan crude prior to the imposition of US sanctions on Caracas in 2019.

Following the sanctions, oil imports from Venezuela stopped within a few months.

E. EXPLAINED

Regime change & bilateral ties

On January 30, Prime Minister Narendra Modi spoke with Venezuela's Acting President Delcy Rodriguez and the two leaders agreed to take the bilateral relations to new heights in the years ahead. The phone call from Rodriguez to Modi was the first since the capture of Venezuelan President Nicolas Maduro and his wife by the United States in the first week of January. Energy was one of the topics covered in the leaders' conversation.

As per India's official trade data, Caracas was New Delhi's fifth-largest supplier of oil in 2019, providing close to 16 million tonnes of crude to Indian refiners. The bilateral trade between India and Venezuela was \$6.40 billion in 2019-20, of which Indian imports — pri-

marily crude oil — were worth \$6.06 billion.

In October 2023, the US eased sanctions on Venezuela's petroleum sector, authorising oil exports without limitation for six months. This led to RIL and a few other Indian refiners restarting oil imports from the country. But imports stopped as the sanction waiver was not extended by Washington after its understanding with Caracas on the conduct of free and fair presidential elections in Venezuela broke down.

A few months later, RIL was able to restart Venezuelan oil imports after obtaining a sanctions waiver from the US. But in the summer of 2025, the company halted oil imports from Venezuela after the Trump administration threatened higher tariffs on countries buying Venezuelan crude.

Since February, after Maduro was captured and Rodriguez became the Acting President, India has resumed oil imports from Venezuela, especially after the war in West Asia has disrupted the energy supply passing through the Strait of Hormuz.



CJI Surya Kant administers the oath of office to senior advocate V S Mohana as a judge of the apex court, in Delhi on Tuesday. ANI

With 5 new judges, SC's strength increases to 37

Express News Service
New Delhi, June 2

FOUR FORMER High Court Chief Justices and a senior advocate were sworn in as Supreme Court judges Tuesday.

Chief Justice of India (CJI) Surya Kant administered the oath of office to former Punjab and Haryana High Court Chief Justice Sheel Nagu, former Chief Justice of Bombay High Court Shree Chandrashekhar, former Chief Justice of Madhya Pradesh High Court Sanjeev Sachdeva, former Chief Justice of High Court of Jammu and Kashmir and Ladakh Arun Palli, and Senior Advocate V S Mohana at a ceremony.

With this, the Supreme Court now has a working strength of 37 judges against a sanctioned strength of 38.

The elevation of senior advocate Mohana to the bench takes the number of women judges of the court to two. Before this, the court had one woman judge, Justice B V Nagarathna, who is due to be CJI in September 2027.

The Supreme Court colle-

gium, headed by CJI Kant, had decided to recommend five names for elevation in meetings held on May 22 and 27.

More vacancies will arise in the top court this year, with at least four judges expected to retire. In March this year, CJI Kant had recommended to the government that the sanctioned strength of Supreme Court judges be increased from the present 34 to 38 so that a permanent constitution bench could be put in place to hear pending matters.

The government accepted the suggestion, and on May 5, it approved the Supreme Court (Number of Judges) Amendment Bill, 2026, which sought to amend the Supreme Court (Number of Judges) Act, 1956, to increase the strength of the court by four.

The last time the strength of the court was increased was in 2019, when an amendment raised it from 30 to 33, excluding the CJI. Originally, the Act had provided for a maximum of 10 judges, excluding the CJI, which was increased to 13 in 1960 and then 17 in 1977.

● ZEENAT WAS BROUGHT TO ODISHA RESERVE FROM MAHARASHTRA TO DIVERSIFY GENE POOL AT SIMILIPAL, WHICH IS HOME TO PSEUDO-MELANISTIC TIGERS BELIEVED TO BE THE RESULT OF SEVERE INBREEDING

How runaway tigress's cubs could save big cat population in Odisha's Similipal

Sujit Bisoyi
Bhubaneswar, June 2

WHEN THE tigress Zeenat arrived in Odisha's Similipal Tiger Reserve in late 2024, wildlife officials hoped it would help balance the gene pool at what is the only home in India of a rare tiger population.

Then, Zeenat vanished. Within days of being released into its new home, the three-year-old tigress slipped out of the reserve, crossed state boundaries, wandered through forests in Jharkhand and West Bengal, and triggered a frantic three-week operation that kept wildlife officials in three states on alert.

For months after its eventual recapture and return to Similipal, Zeenat remained under close watch, its every movement tracked through a radio collar as forest officials

wondered whether the ambitious translocation experiment would ultimately succeed.

This week, they got some good news. Camera traps installed deep inside the forests of Similipal have captured images of Zeenat carrying four cubs, offering what officials describe as a major milestone in Odisha's efforts to strengthen the reserve's tiger population.

"The cubs are believed to be around three to four weeks old and their movements are being continuously monitored," Similipal Tiger Reserve Field Director Prakash Chand Gogineni told *The Indian Express*. For conservationists, the significance of the photographs extends far beyond the birth of four cubs.

Zeenat was brought to Similipal from the Tadoba-Andhari Tiger Reserve in Maharashtra in November 2024 as part of

a carefully planned effort to diversify the gene pool of tigers in the reserve. Similipal, spread across northern Odisha, is home to India's only known population of pseudo-melanistic tigers — popularly called black tigers because of the unusually thick black stripes that merge across their coats. Scientists believe the trait became common because the tiger population remained geographically isolated for generations, resulting in extensive inbreeding.

While the striking appearance of Similipal's tigers has drawn global attention, conservationists have long worried about the genetic consequences of such isolation. Officials said Zeenat's relocation was intended to introduce fresh genetic material into the population and reduce the prevalence of inbreeding-linked traits that



Zeenat with its cubs at Similipal Tiger Reserve. X/@MOHANMODISHA

could threaten the long-term survival of the reserve's tigers.

"As Zeenat is from Tadoba, it does not carry the genetic trait commonly found among Similipal tigers. Its cubs are therefore expected to have a broader genetic base, which was the primary objective of the translocation programme," Gogineni said.

Principal Chief Conservator of Forests (Wildlife) P K Jha said after Zeenat was released free into the wild in April 2025, it mated with a resident male but did not conceive. "The tigress moved freely inside Similipal and formed a territory in the core area. Once again, it mated with a resident male in January

2026," said Jha. He said the birth of the tigress's cubs marks the achievement of the primary objective of the tiger translocation project, which was increasing the genetic diversity of Similipal tigers. Zeenat's offspring with a male tiger from Similipal Tiger Reserve will have high genetic diversity and be helpful in securing the future of Similipal's tiger population, Jha said.

The achievement comes after a turbulent beginning. Soon after being released into a soft enclosure in Similipal's northern division, Zeenat began an unexpected journey that took her nearly 300 kilometres across three states. Its movements became a daily source of anxiety for forest officials as it moved through forest corridors, crossed human settlements and repeatedly evaded capture teams.

After 21 days on the move, Zeenat was finally tranquillised near Gosaindihi village in West Bengal's Bankura district. It was initially taken to Kolkata's Alipore Zoo before being brought back to Similipal in accordance with guidelines issued by the National Tiger Conservation Authority (NTCA). Officials subsequently housed it in a larger enclosure before releasing it again into the wild under intensive monitoring. Since then, its radio collar has provided forest officials with a near-continuous stream of information about its movements and adaptation to the Similipal landscape. Now, with Zeenat successfully raising cubs in the wild, officials believe the tigress has finally made Similipal her home. The birth of the cubs has also prompted discussions on whether the radio collar, fitted

during the translocation project, should be removed.

Forest officials said any decision would be taken by a high-level committee comprising representatives of the Odisha government and the NTCA. "For now, monitoring will continue for some more weeks," said a senior forest department official. "A decision on removing the collar will be taken once the cubs begin moving independently."

Odisha CM Mohan Charan Majhi called the development a "proud chapter" in Odisha's wildlife conservation efforts. "This success not only signifies an increase in the tiger population in the state but also stands as an excellent testament to our administrative foresight in protecting biodiversity and creating a safe and robust habitat for wildlife," Majhi wrote on X.



At a temple in Vijinigiripalem, a village in Visakhapatnam, women dismiss the idea of cash incentives for childbirth. NIKHILA HENRY

Andhra Pradesh says have more children.

“Why not ask women what they want?”

HER ANKLETS chime as she softly carries a tune on board the Hyderabad-Visakhapatnam Vande Bharat. When she is ready to talk, she does it just as casually. “I have PCOS (Polycystic Ovary Syndrome) and mood swings. I become happy when my uterus is happy and sad when my uterus is sad. I don’t want to bear children,” says S Mounika. “Hush,” says her friend, Ramya, from across the aisle, turning to look at the other passengers who have turned curious about the conversation.

The 23-year-olds, both Bsc Computer Science graduates from Visakhapatnam, are on their way home to Pithapuram, in Kakinada district of Andhra Pradesh, after a job interview with a cargo firm in Hyderabad.

Mounika goes on, “It’s been three years since I graduated. No job. The Chief Minister should think about creating employment for the youth rather than asking us to have more children.”

In response to the state’s Total Fertility Rate (TFR) or the number of children per adult woman) of 1.4, among the lowest in the country, the Andhra Pradesh government in March introduced a draft Population Management Policy, which aims to encourage families to have two or three children. After announcing Rs 25,000 last year for families that bear a second child, at a public meeting in Narsannapeta, Srikakulam, on May 16, Chief Minister N Chandrababu Naidu rolled out more incentives. “We will provide Rs 30,000 for a third child and Rs 40,000 for a fourth child. Isn’t this the right decision?”

The audience of mostly men whistled and clapped. He then turned to where the women sat and said, “What do you think? Isn’t this the right decision?” The video pans to show some of them smiling.

The demographic and economic argument behind Naidu’s appeal — that a falling birthrate will have long-term consequences for the state’s productivity and strain the government’s finances — may, however, come up against something far more fundamental: women’s autonomy.

No where is that expressed with better clarity than in Visakhapatnam — at 1.3, the district with the one of the lowest TFRs in Andhra Pradesh — and few say it as firmly as Mounika.

The daughter of a lorry driver and a homemaker, she says, “I want a government job, so I am trying to clear the Staff Selection Commission exams. I want to take care of my parents; not sacrifice everything for marriage and children. Someday, I might adopt a girl child, though. Do you think I will get a life partner who thinks like me? I really hope so. Fingers crossed, fingers crossed.” She holds up both her hands, the fingers in a desperate knot.

The cost of raising a child

In Visakhapatnam’s Appanapalem village, which sits below the famous Simhachalam temple, Papiamma, 70, talks of a time when having children wasn’t about choice. “Whatever God gave, I accepted. Those days, everyone had four children or more,” says the mother of four, sitting in a room on the terrace of the two-storied house her late husband built, and where she now lives with her children and grandchildren.

Those days, she says, few dreamt of lives beyond their village. Papiamma used to cultivate vegetables on the family’s land, graze cattle and feed her children. She even grew a little tobacco on 10 cents of land.

A 23-year-old job-seeker, an 18-year-old widow with a toddler, a 70-year-old grandmother of nine and a 36-year-old expecting her third child. As Andhra Pradesh encourages couples to have more children to counter falling fertility rates, NIKHILA HENRY travels to Visakhapatnam and finds that the policy may come up against something fundamental: women’s autonomy

Sitting beside her on the cot, her son Appal Raju, 52, talks of the impact of a government policy from a different time. “I have three children because of my wife’s insistence. But because of that, I was not able to contest the local body elections,” he says.

Until 2024, the state’s two-child norm banned people with more than two children from getting elected to public offices.

Now, in a reversal of expectations, just when the government wants people to have more children, Raju says his eldest daughter, who got married recently, is clear she won’t have more than one. “She says her husband’s brother and wife too have just one child. What can you do? Children decide on their own nowadays,” he laughs.

The family’s fortunes had turned in the early 2000s, when the price of their two-acre family land shot up. With nine grandchildren to bring up, Papiamma says, the family sold most of the land, except for the little patch surrounding their house. “My sons were farmers, but now, they do nothing. Our lives depend on the fortunes of my grandchildren,” she says. All of them, she says, have studied beyond graduation but none have jobs.

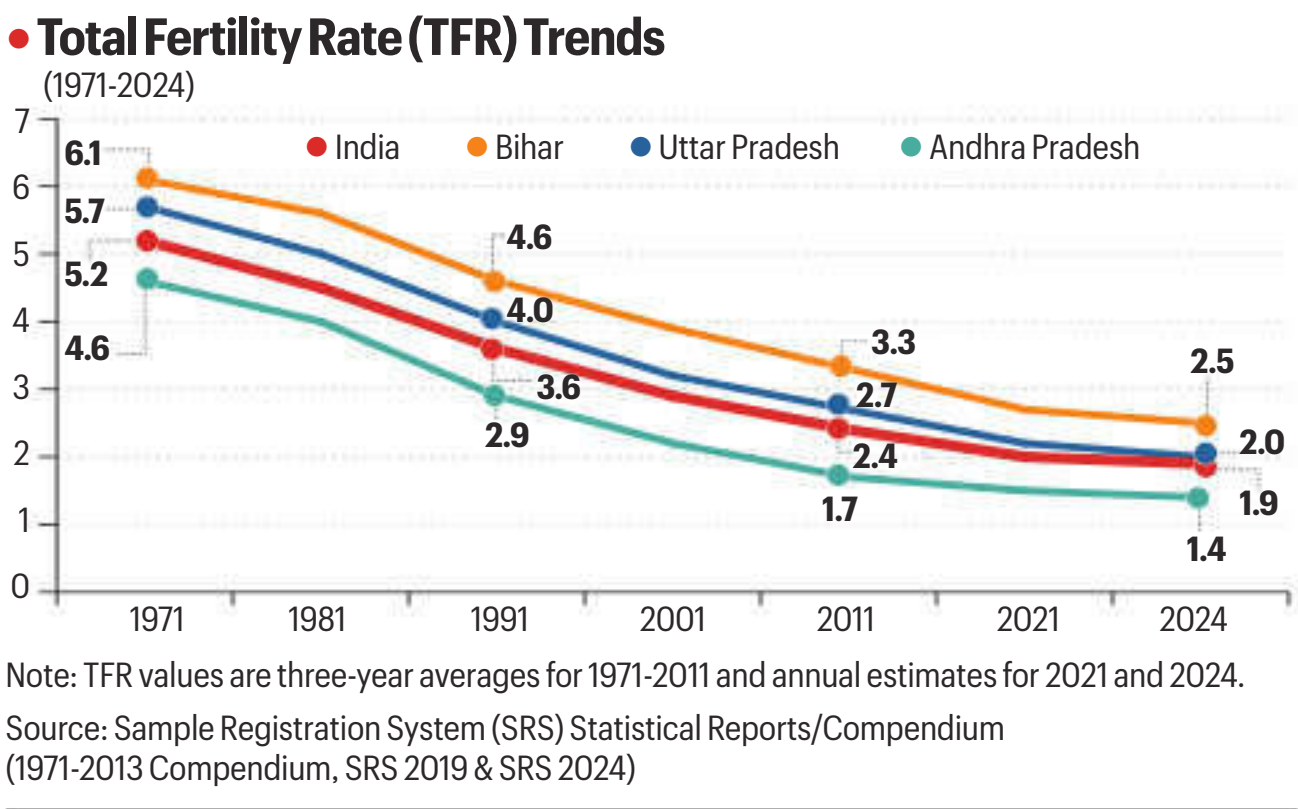
“Instead of providing jobs, the CM says have more children. Seems like he is mocking people like us,” she says. “Potti prapancham,” says Raju in Telugu, referring to the dogged rat race that his children will have to endure.

Since 2018, Naidu has been publicly expressing concern at the state’s declining fertility rates that’s far below that of states such as Bihar (2.5) and Uttar Pradesh (2), and in line with that of its neighbours in the south. While the other southern states have framed the issue in terms of delimitation and the potential impact on their representation in Parliament, Naidu has justified his population policy on economic grounds.

In Adavivaram village, L Muthiyalam, 40, and her neighbours have an economic argument of their own. Bringing up children is no small feat, says the mother of three — two girls and a boy. “Had I not wanted a boy child, I would have stopped with two,” says Muthiyalam, who sells the coconut she grows, earning less than Rs 100 a day.

Her children, she says, are educated enough not to risk multiple pregnancies. “My daughters speak of having one child each, though they are yet to be married. We are dependent entirely on farming and cattle, and they know how expensive it is to bring up children,” says Muthiyalam.

In neighbouring Vijinigiripalem, a group of 15 women sits on the floor of a local temple, discussing children and choice. Swearing by the presiding deity, Lord Hanuman, they say they don’t want cash incentives for childbirth because bringing up children costs a lot. “At least two lakh ru-



pees a year goes into just education and healthcare,” estimates Appalanarasamma, 62, who raised her four daughters, and got them married.

She has a counter incentive for the government. “Let Chandrababu Naidu assure us that the firstborns in each family will be given a government job. Then these young girls can consider the offer,” she says.

Her friend B Jayalalitha says she raised her three children with her husband’s earnings from his cycle repair shop. “We took loans to educate them up to B.Tech. I can’t imagine any of them sacrificing so much to bring up their own children,” she says.

Her younger neighbour M Shyalama, 32, is a mother of two. “I can’t think of having more children. Ayyo, I have had enough already... My body won’t allow me to raise more children. I am tired all the time.”

‘If I make it alive...’

The Andhra Pradesh government calls its policy, titled *Pillale Sampada* or ‘Children are Wealth’, a shift — from the earlier population control to population management, “a rights-based approach” that emphasises reproductive health and rights, informed choice, and individual well-being.

Officials involved in the policy and Telugu Desam Party leaders pointed to a government note that read, “It is not an initiative to increase the number of children, but an initiative that adopts population care — a rights-based, voluntary framework that enables informed choices.”

While calling the draft policy’s emphasis on population management an “important shift”, Professor K S James, former director of the International Institute of Population Studies who is currently at the Centre for Health and Wellbeing at Princeton University, USA, says government population policies often do not address underlying factors for lower fertility rates.

“In the West, population drop was caused by a drop in the number of marriages. That’s not the case in India — people are getting married, but late. Here, men and women are struggling to get jobs to secure their future. Any public policy should be aimed at creating jobs which will help young couples to marry and have children

as per their choice,” he says.

Those working on women’s causes say the policy does not adequately consider its consequences for women’s well-being.

“There could be women who are forced to bear a child just so the family can receive the incentive. The burden of raising the child will ultimately fall on women, and this is not in line with reproductive choice and autonomy. The government should support women through long-term childcare, stronger health systems, and services that allow them to make free and informed choices,” says Poonam Muttreja, academic and Executive Director at Population Foundation of India.

At the government-run King George Hospital, an obstetrician attending to patients in the Out Patient Department says on condition of anonymity, “Women insist on tubectomy after they have one child or two children. All this while, we also have been encouraging this because it is a healthier option for young women.”

A senior doctor, however, said there are several women who deliver more than two children at the hospital.

“These days, every second pregnancy is a C-section, which costs more than Rs 1 lakh. What will we do with a one-time grant of Rs 30,000 or 40,000?” says one of the women queuing up to meet the doctor.

Not far from the hospital, Nehru Nagar, an urban slum in Dondaparthi area of Visakhapatnam city, is bustling — children running around noisily, women playing board games, some cooking inside tiny kitchens. In the melee, stands Shanthi, 36, heavily pregnant, her hands supporting her tired back. She had two children, both girls, in quick succession — a two-year-old and a one-year-old — and is now seven months into her third pregnancy. Sinking into a chair, Shanthi says, “I am happy the government has announced Rs 30,000 for a third child. I will get the money if I make it out of the labour room,” she says.

“Tch tch... what are you saying,” says one of the elderly women in the group. “She hardly eats anything. She is always sick”.

“There could be women who are forced to bear a child just so the family can get the incentive. The burden will fall on women,” says Poonam Muttreja of Population Foundation of India

Shanthi says she decided to have her third child out of “family compulsions”. Her husband’s siblings have one child each. “They got the sterilisation procedures done. Now, the family thinks we should have more children,” she says.

Would she consider giving birth to a fourth child? She sits up with a start, “No. I am weak. I cannot do it again”.

The other women take over, talking of how child rearing responsibilities are never shared. “We have husbands who are either dead or as good as dead because they just lie around drinking,” says Gauri, 40, adding she had filed a domestic violence case against her husband to make him “mend his ways”.

G Revanthi talks of how her husband died of alcoholism and her daughter Sharon’s husband too met with the same end, leaving the 18-year-old with a 2-year-old.

As she tries to feed her baby who is perched on her hip, Sharon says, “I cannot think of marrying or giving birth to children again”. Would she want to study further? “Yes, I would like that,” she smiles.

There is less of a consensus among a group of women workers of the TDP who have assembled at the party office in Visakhapatnam’s Ramnagar.

Jujuvarupu Hema, 54, says she got a tubectomy done after the birth of her daughter. “After winning the 1994 elections, Chandrababu Naidu garu had announced, ‘One child is enough for us’. I am such a hard-working member of the TDP that I just informed my husband and got the tubectomy done. Now that the CM is talking about the state’s falling population, I have told my daughter, an MBA graduate, to bear at least three children”.

Others quickly step in to disagree. “I am speaking from my experience of having three daughters. We need free education, healthcare and other government plans to support the children we bear. In this day and age, we need at least a house of our own to bring up children,” says Soujanya, another TDP worker.

The women cadre raise a rabble as they vie with each other to explain what it takes to raise more children. “There should be some job security,” says B Lalitha.

Away from the candour at the party office, TDP’s doctor-turned politician Gottipati Lakshmi takes a more disciplined party line. “What the government is advocating is child planning. It’s futuristic because women are at the

centre of the policy. It’s not coercive because the government is clear that the policy is only suggestive.”

‘Children... not on my mind’

At an upscale coffee shop by the sea, politics is not a great starting point for a conversation — certainly not the subject of having more, or any, children.

Nitya, 20, a BBA graduate, says, “Children... That’s not on my mind. I’m thinking of studying in Canada and earning a lot before I turn 30. And then, maybe I’ll come back and settle down in Vizag. I’m working to a plan.”

For most of them, children are nowhere part of that plan.

“My mother suffered a stroke after delivering my third sibling. I don’t want to risk my health or body by bearing more than one child, if at all,” says Nitya, sipping on iced tea.

Sitting at an adjoining table are Rohan Shaji and Srisai Bhavya Karri, MBA graduates and friends who are “looking for jobs”.

“How can anyone think of raising children without financial security?,” says Shaji. Karri has an idea. “Before framing a policy, why not ask the women what they want?”

The Editorial Page

WEDNESDAY, JUNE 3, 2026

In navigating Trump's US & Xi's China, Japan is imagining a new Asia story


RAJA MANDALA

BY C RAJA MOHAN

SINCE WORLD War II, Japan has deliberately defined itself as a peaceful nation. Relying on the US for its security, Tokyo built one of the world's largest economies while renouncing nuclear weapons, avoiding the use of force, and refusing to project its conventional military power. That era is now drawing to a close.

China's growing regional assertiveness and America's ambivalence in Asia, especially regarding the defence of Taiwan against potential Chinese aggression, have caused much of Asia to complain about the Donald Trump administration and mutter about its likely abandonment of the region. Tokyo, however, is not wringing its hands; it is acting to defend itself and help others secure themselves against Chinese expansionism and the US volatility.

At the annual Shangri-La Dialogue in Singapore last week, Japanese Defence Minister Shinjiro Koizumi unveiled three broad directions of a new security policy: To step up national defence spending and military modernisation, increase defence cooperation with friendly nations, and lift restrictions on the export of arms. The shift marks one of the major transformations in Asian geopolitics since the end of the Cold War.

For decades, Japan's defence industry

was largely inward-looking. Strict policy controls limited arms exports and constrained military cooperation with foreign partners. Tokyo has now reached a very different conclusion. It argues that preserving peace in Asia requires active participation in shaping the regional balance of power. The result is a historic relaxation of arms exports announced in April this year.

The most visible symbol of this change is the agreement last month to supply 11 up-graded *Mogami*-class frigates to Australia. The contract, estimated at nearly \$7 billion, is the largest defence export in Japan's post-war history, and goes beyond a simple commercial transaction. It creates a framework for Japan's long-term defence-industrial collaboration with Australia and other regional partners. It also points to the construction of regional defence networks that are not dependent on Washington.

In Singapore, Koizumi announced that New Zealand is also interested in the purchase of *Mogami*-class frigates from Tokyo. The emerging Japan-Australia-New Zealand security triangle is not a formal alliance but part of a new web of defence cooperation involving production, logistics, technology sharing and interoperability. Similar conversations are unfolding between Japan and the Philippines, as well as with other maritime states anxious about the changing balance of power in Asia.

Koizumi rejected China's high-pitched accusations about Japan's militarism and rearmament. Pointing to China's expanding nuclear arsenal and growing conventional military power, Koizumi gently suggested that "the pot is calling the kettle black". China can't dramatically build up its own military capabilities, indulge in co-

Tokyo is not breaking from its One China policy. But it has increasingly signalled that a military conflict over Taiwan would have direct consequences for Japan

ercion of all kinds and accuse others of rearmament and militarism.

What is driving Tokyo's new military doctrine is not nostalgia for great-power status in the imperial era, but anxiety about the future balance of power in Asia. The Taiwan question has sharpened these concerns. Under Prime Minister Sanae Takachi, Japan has moved closer than ever to publicly acknowledging that its own security is linked to peace in Taiwan.

Tokyo is not breaking from its One China policy. But it has increasingly signalled that a military conflict over Taiwan would have direct consequences for Japan. Chinese reactions have been predictably fierce, with Beijing accusing Tokyo of crossing red lines and interfering in China's internal affairs.

But Takaichi's Japan is not willing to quiver under Chinese bullying. Tokyo believes preservation of peace in the Taiwan Strait is critical to regional stability. This does not mean Japan seeks confrontation. Rather, it reflects a growing belief that deterrence requires both clarity and capability.

The Taiwan issue has become a litmus test for Japan's strategic evolution. For decades, Tokyo preferred ambiguity. Today, it believes peace in Taiwan is critical for Asian security. That the US Secretary of War, Pete Hegseth, tiptoed around the question of Taiwan at the Shangri-La Dialogue is widely viewed as part of President Trump's effort to please China's leader, Xi Jinping, after the Beijing summit last month.

To be fair, Hegseth reaffirmed the US commitment to the balance of power in Asia; he also argued that the US will not allow China to exercise hegemony over Asia. But the way Trump is going about it

has triggered anxieties all around. Hegseth also called on the allies and partners to do more for themselves.

On its part, Japan is trying to reconcile two strategic imperatives. The first is preserving the American alliance, which has been the foundation of its security. The second is reducing excessive dependence on the United States by strengthening regional security partnerships and creating Asian defence-industrial networks.

The imperatives for Delhi are similar—engage Washington on defence where beneficial, but also simultaneously enhance strategic collaboration with regional powers like Japan, South Korea, Australia, and the ASEAN countries. Plans for bilateral and regional defence collaboration already exist in Delhi. What India needs is an urgent and purposeful transformation of plans into concrete outcomes.

Unlike China, India has long welcomed Japan to play a larger security role in Asia. What has changed is Tokyo's willingness to act upon that logic. The old Japan was an economic giant and a military minimalist. The new Japan seeks to be something different: A security partner, a defence-industrial power and an active participant in shaping the balance of power in Asia. Tokyo's strategic reorientation is not merely a Japanese story. It is part of Asia's wider search for a new equilibrium in an era of Chinese power and American reorientation.

The writer is a contributing editor on international affairs for The Indian Express. He is a distinguished professor at the Motwani Jadeja Institute of American Studies, Jindal Global University and holds the Korea Foundation Chair on Asian geopolitics at the Council for Strategic and Defence Research, Delhi

From Ladakh, a sea buckthorn parable about enterprise


CHIRAG PASWAN

ON A recent visit to Ladakh, I drove from Leh to Tirth, a village in Nubra, crossing Khardung La to reach a food processing unit in one of the remotest corners of the country. The drive explained the place's economics better than any report could. Here, altitude, weather and distance are not background conditions; they are built into the price of every product that must leave the valley. Inside the unit, there were no sea buckthorn berries.

It was May, and the harvest had ended months earlier, in the short autumn window when the fruit comes off the bush. What stood there instead were juice and pulp sealed and labelled, and dried berries packed from last autumn's harvest. The unit also had mobile aseptic processing capacity. That detail stayed with me because it demonstrated the enterprise's practical intelligence. They had understood the problem clearly: In Ladakh, the crop is brief, the road is long, and the berry cannot wait. So the first act of processing had to be brought closer to the harvest.

Food processing is usually discussed in the language of large plants, investment figures and export targets. In Tirth, the point was narrower and more immediate. The unit showed that enterprise in a remote region is often an answer to necessity.

I had seen the same point earlier in Leh, in the work of Deachen Angmo. A few years ago, she earned Rs 8,000 a month as a wage labourer. Today, she runs K-Top Food Processing, a unit built around sea buckthorn, one of Ladakh's most difficult crops. She buys the berry from local collectors, turns it into juice, pulp, dried berries and jam under her own brand, and sells to markets well beyond the Union Territory.

Sea buckthorn brings the difficulty and the opportunity into one plant. The shrub grows over cold, thorny ground. The berries are small, soft and hard to pick. The harvest window is short, and once the fruit is off the bush, it cannot wait for processing somewhere distant. It has to be cleaned, pulped, dried or preserved quickly. Delay costs quality, and

lost quality costs price. Deachen's unit grew because the support she received met the crop's actual needs. Under the Pradhan Mantri Formalisation of Micro Food Processing Enterprises Scheme, she accessed finance and invested in the machinery needed to process sea buckthorn quickly, package it properly and sell it under her own brand.

A woman who once worked as a wage labourer now runs an enterprise with a turnover in crores, employs workers, and sustains a supply chain linked to local collectors and families in her own community. Her unit also points to the larger gap. To make such examples less rare, local processors need finance, machinery and formal support before a perishable crop can become a marketable product. PMFME has helped create that starting point in Ladakh: Under the scheme, 101 loans have been sanctioned, and 89 have been disbursed to micro food processing units across the Union Territory, and seed capital assistance of Rs 1.81 crore has been approved for 651 SHG members.

A single enterprise may process a local crop, but it cannot alone provide storage, testing, packaging, branding, market access and larger shared facilities. That requires common infrastructure. Under PMFME, common incubation centres have been approved for sea buckthorn processing in Leh and apricot processing in Kargil, giving local producers access to facilities that would otherwise remain beyond their individual reach. Shared infrastructure addresses one part of the gap. Collective support and product identity address another. That is why branding and marketing support have been approved for sea buckthorn products under "Wonder Berry" and apricot products under "Kargil Gold".

Deachen Angmo's journey from a wage labourer to the head of a thriving multi-crore enterprise is powerful proof of what happens when local potential meets the right institutional support. The ultimate goal of our efforts is not just to celebrate a single success story, but to replicate it across every valley.

The writer is Cabinet Minister of Food Processing Industries of India

When a distorted autopsy denies justice


VRINDA SHUKLA

A YOUNG married woman found hanging by the noose is adjudged "dead due to uncertain causes" by the doctor conducting the autopsy, who goes on to preserve her viscera samples. Despite the registration of an FIR alleging a dowry death, the autopsy report makes it impossible for the police to make arrests until the viscera testing results are received, which could take more than a year. Despite a visible ligature mark on the victim's neck, the doctor, ignorantly or deliberately, takes no stand on whether the hanging was ante mortem or post mortem. A police appeal to review the autopsy report is dismissed as infeasible due to the unavailability of videography and the body having been cremated. Such subversion of the importance of forensic evidence is common, particularly in cases of homicide or while trying to distinguish homicide from suicide. The distortion in the autopsy report may be due to incompetence, malfeasance or lack of resources.

It takes the national outrage over the death of the educated, vibrant Twisha Sharma, allegedly a victim of torture by a lawyer husband and a mother-in-law, a former judge, to persuade a high court to order a repeat autopsy. Even then, while her family appealed for a second autopsy, her body was kept in the mortuary at -4°C—way higher than is needed to preserve a body for a longer duration—with no preservation facilities in the state capital.

Without prejudice to the facts of the case of Twisha Sharma, there is no denying that the collection of forensic evidence, particularly autopsies, is vulnerable to distortions. In most states, medico-legal autopsies are carried out only at government hospitals or medical colleges. Government doctors, fatigued from their tremendous patient load and a huge number of routine autopsies on account of accidental deaths, working in decrepit post-mortem houses, carry out perfunctory procedures with compromised quality. Only in sensitive cases do the police request that the autopsy be conducted by a panel of doctors with videography. However, the output of such videography by untrained persons is amateurish and hardly useful for a constructive review of the autopsy.

There is an urgent need to consider allowing private hospitals with state-of-the-art infrastructure and well-trained doctors to conduct autopsies. This would ease the load on government facilities and help launch advanced forensics programmes at private institutions, ultimately producing more qualified experts. A regulatory and supervisory framework can be put in place to ensure these private hospitals are held accountable.

There is also an urgent need to upgrade and standardise the district-level physical infrastructure where autopsies are conducted to ensure proper ventilation, sufficient lighting and requisite tools. Ceiling- or wall-mounted videography systems, programmed to professionally record the process, enabled with AI models like Claude for superior video analytics, are a pressing necessity. Finally, what is most imperative is that cases of wilful tampering or negligence in the collection and handling of forensic evidence be held to account. Else we risk jeopardising even the sanctity of science as a potent aid in the pursuit of justice.

The writer is an IPS officer. Views are personal

There is an urgent need to consider allowing private hospitals with state-of-the-art infrastructure and well-trained doctors to conduct autopsies

The Ideas Page

WEDNESDAY, JUNE 3, 2026

Take the right reform lessons from Indonesia, don't dress up a flawed system



SURJIT S BHALLA

IN AN earlier article ('BJP is winning the elections, but losing the economy,' *IE*, May 21), I had expressed worry and concern over declining private investment in India. I had suggested that the large reduction in the share of private investment was a decade-old problem, and one most likely caused by a worsening investment climate in India. I suggested that the investment climate had deteriorated following (induced by?) the stringent rules against foreign direct investment (FDI) enacted by the 2015 Model Bilateral Investment Treaty. The government constructively answered, via CEA Ananth Nageswaran ('We need to speed up economic reforms, but pessimism obscures, doesn't illuminate,' *IE*, May 23). In this article, I use Indonesian and Indian BITs for illumination.

Indonesia: A tale of triumph: In 2014, Indonesia made a bold announcement that it was scrapping every one of its existing Bilateral Investment Treaties (BITs) and starting over with a new model. The trigger was a pair of foreign mining companies — Churchill Mining and Newmont — who had sued the Indonesian government for alleged violations of foreign investment law. Indonesia won both cases.

The Churchill Mining affair is especially instructive. The Indonesian government proved in court that Churchill's local partner, the Ridlatama Group, had forged documents — including mechanically reproduced signatures of local government officials — to fraudulently obtain mining concessions. Ridlatama was well-connected, but Indonesia's anti-corruption agency, the KPK, had real teeth. It deployed phone-tapping and financial-tracking powers to hunt down the regional politicians who had traded mining licences for campaign cash. By 2016, the KPK had indicted over 30 senior officials — among them six parliamen-

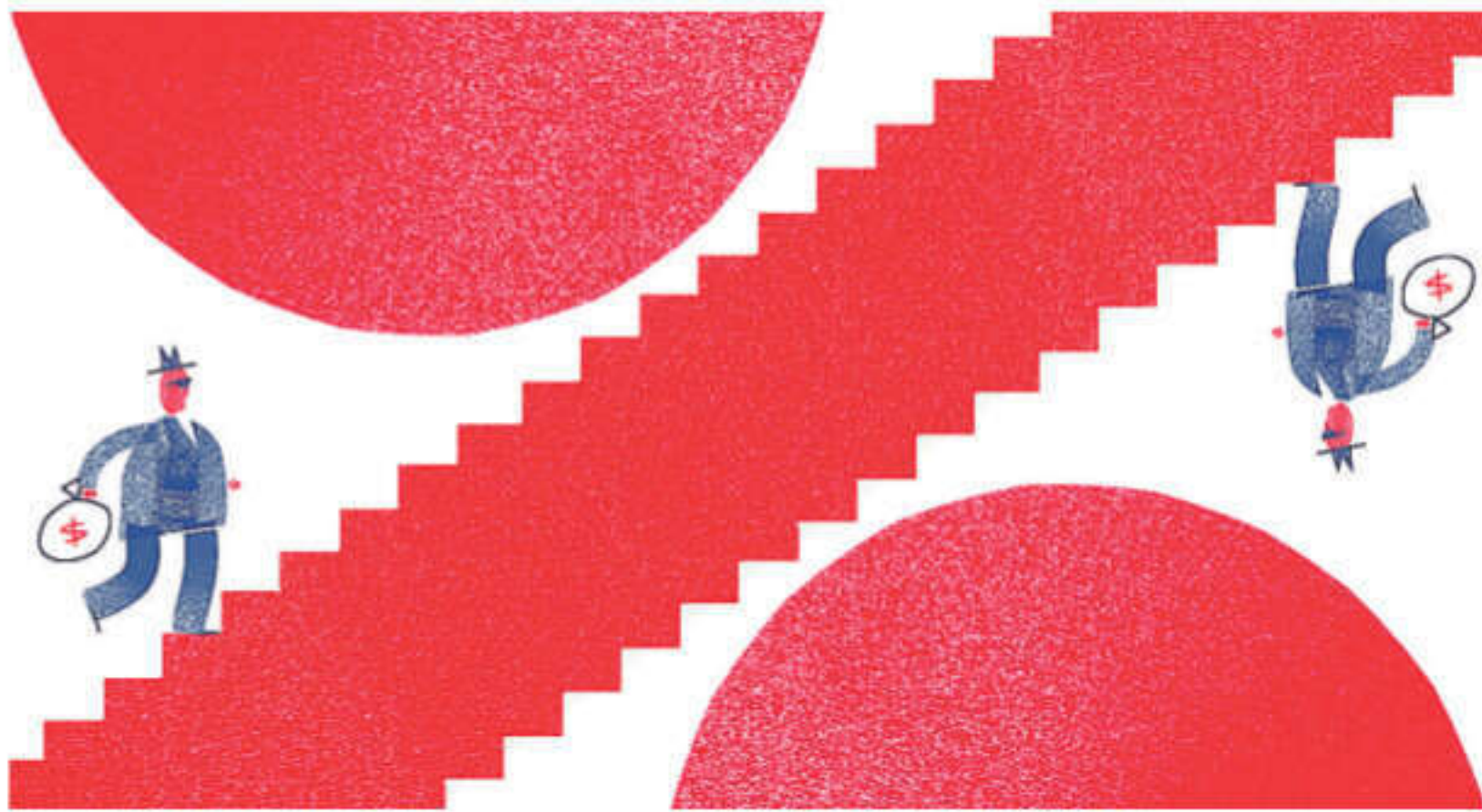


ILLUSTRATION: C R SASIKUMAR

tarians, three governors, and four district heads — for accepting bribes to fabricate resource permits. The corrupt officials went to jail. The Ridlatama Group was dissolved and its mining licences revoked, effectively shutting the door on prosecution of its executives while delivering the same result: The company ceased to exist.

The international business community warned Indonesia that taking on powerful multinationals would scare off the foreign investment it badly needed. That warning has not aged well. In the decade before 2015, Indonesia attracted an average of \$14 billion a year in inward foreign direct investment (FDI), with net FDI running at 1.1 per cent of GDP. In the decade since its new approach, inward FDI has risen to \$20 billion a year, and net FDI to 1.4 per cent of GDP — even as global FDI flows became more competitive, rising from \$0.65 trillion in 2004 to \$1.6 trillion today.

Indonesia has since signed only two new BITs, one of them with Singapore. That treaty reveals the country's new philosophy: A cooling-off period of just 12 months, followed by a three-judge panel — one chosen by each party,

and a presiding judge agreed upon by both, who must be a national of neither country. It is lean, neutral, and fast.

India: A tale of self-inflicted woes: India watched Indonesia and drew the wrong lessons. Like Indonesia, India cancelled its existing BITs in 2016, prompted by a dispute with an Australian mining company, White Industries. But the Indian case had a twist: The domestic party was not a private firm but Coal India — a company owned by the Indian government itself. White Industries had won an arbitration award of just \$2.2 million. Yet thanks to crushing backlogs and procedural gridlock in the Calcutta and Delhi High Courts, a decade passed with no result, and no award. In 2011, White Industries sued the Government of India, won, and the Supreme Court ordered Coal India to pay interest and legal costs on top of the original sum.

India's response to this embarrassment was to pass a new Model BIT in 2015 that is the most restrictive one passed by any government — it is a model of defensive state protection. In contrast to Indonesia's requirement of a 12-month cooling-off period, the In-

Two new governments in 2014 — Indonesia and India. Both wanted reform of BITs. One chose the forward path. The other chose regression. One gained international investors' respect and money. The other gained contempt and exodus



RAJA MENON

ALTHOUGH INDIA is not a direct combatant in the Iran war, it has been impacted by inflation, fiscal stress, slower growth, supply chain disruption, pressure on agriculture, and a large outflow of capital. Has something similar happened before?

In 18th-century Europe, Great Britain and France were locked in a struggle for supremacy. France had over twice the population of Britain and three times its GDP. Yet between 1750 and 1800, Britain's economy tripled. That growth financed victory over France and the loss of its colonies in America and India. The usual explanation is the Industrial Revolution and the Bank of England. But later scholarship has questioned both claims. The Industrial Revolution, it is argued, began only around 1770, and the agricultural surplus said to have funded it has never been convincingly established.

A more persuasive explanation lies in the empire. British power was built not simply at home but through the capture of wealth abroad, especially in India. The first Indian force trained to European standards was raised at Madras by Stringer Lawrence and Robert Clive. Sailing up the Hooghly on Royal Navy ships, they defeated the Nawab of Bengal at Plassey in 1757. The resulting treaty gave the East India Company the right of *diwani*, or land revenue, in Bengal, Bihar and Orissa, a region whose population exceeded that of Great Britain. After 1857, the British Crown replaced the Company, but the logic remained the same. India's textile trade

Don't forget the economy in military strategy

was destroyed and replaced by Lancashire cloth made with Indian cotton. India was conquered by sea by a country one-tenth its size, 5,000 miles away, while it remained tied to a continental outlook and treated the oceans as *kala pani*.

Can something like that happen again? Not in the same way, but the deeper logic has returned.

Around 2015, China-watchers began to notice that the Chinese Dream, the 13th and 14th Five-Year Plans, and the National Security Strategy of 2015 together pointed to a grand strategy aimed at strategic pre-eminence. Basil Liddell Hart defined grand strategy as an all-of-government approach to strategic competition in which war is the least desirable option. China's version is different. It seeks influence through economic dependence, infrastructure finance, market access, energy corridors, supply-chain dominance, control of digital nodes and the ability to deny them, pressure on cable landing stations, and efforts to weaken the dollar and bypass SWIFT.

Nowhere is this more evident than in China's use of proxies, especially Pakistan and Iran. Beijing has supplied military assistance to Pakistan, which allowed it to obtain targeting data during Operation Sindoor. Iran, too, received similar support to target US installations in the Gulf. This is modern strategic competition: Not conquest by massed armies, but influence, denial and remote reach.

China's aim has not been territorial annexation. It has been to tie India down south of the Himalayas

Chinese thinking also reflects Sun Tzu's enduring insight: The greatest victory is won without fighting. Another is that distant conflicts are decided by shaping the environment without battle. From enabling Pakistan to develop its nuclear weapons to the border crises at Sumdorong Chu, Doklam and Galwan, the pattern for India has been unmistakable. China's aim has not been territorial annexation. It has been to tie India down south of the Himalayas, consuming its attention and limiting its freedom of action.

India must therefore think strategically, not sentimentally. Its real leverage against China's \$20-trillion economy is not a Himalayan stalemate but its maritime geography. India sits astride the Indian Ocean and can influence the status of the Strait of Malacca, the Strait of Hormuz, the Red Sea and the Suez Canal. Negotiating with Beijing over the land boundary, a secondary issue in its grand design, without the backing of hard power at sea, would be another capitulation. And the idea of a tri-service, five-domain theatre command against a declining player with a GDP lower than Tamil Nadu's would be another error of judgment.

History does not repeat itself in the same form. But its methods, adapted to new technology and new instruments of power, do return. India should remember that before it confuses tactical activity with strategic wisdom.

Menon is a retired rear admiral and author of The Long View from Delhi



KAMINI WALIA

THE RECENT approval of Zaynich by the US FDA marks a watershed moment for the Indian innovation ecosystem. For decades, India has been recognised as the "pharmacy of the world", supplying affordable medicines and vaccines at scale. With Zaynich, it has demonstrated something equally important: The ability to discover, develop, and globally commercialise a novel antibiotic that meets the standards of one of the world's most demanding regulators.

This comes at a critical time. Antimicrobial resistance (AMR) is among the most serious threats to global health, and India bears a disproportionate share of this burden. Zay-

nich's development has been informed by the realities of AMR in India. Resistance mechanisms prevalent in Indian healthcare settings, and clinical and microbiological data generated from Indian patients and institutions, have helped shape the product's development. In many ways, this is a medicine designed with some of the world's toughest resistance challenges in mind.

The FDA approval sends a powerful message: Indian drug innovators have arrived on the global stage. Indian firms are no longer confined to manufacturing generic medicines or incremental improvements. They are increasingly capable of undertaking the high-risk, scientifically demanding journey of discovering and developing new therapeutics with global relevance. This is precisely the transformation policymakers have long sought to encourage.

India now has an opportunity to ensure its regulatory framework keeps pace with its innovation ambitions. It would be paradoxical if a drug developed with substantial Indian scientific contributions and approved by a stringent international regulator were to face prolonged delays before reaching Indian patients. The Central Drugs Standard Control Organisation should consider an expedited pathway for innovative antibiotics

The CDSCO should consider an expedited pathway for innovative antibiotics that address critical unmet medical needs and have already undergone rigorous evaluation by trusted regulators

that address critical unmet medical needs and have already undergone rigorous evaluation by trusted regulatory authorities.

Such a pathway need not compromise scientific rigor. Regulatory reliance models, increasingly adopted around the world, allow regulators to focus on issues of local relevance while avoiding duplication of assessments already completed to internationally accepted standards.

India should also recognise the strategic importance of rewarding innovation. Drug discovery is expensive, uncertain, and time-consuming. Every successful product creates confidence among investors, researchers, academic institutions, and biotechnology start-ups that India can compete globally in pharmaceutical innovation. A responsive regulatory pathway would signal that India values and supports those will-

ing to undertake this challenging journey.

At the same time, expedited access must be accompanied by strong antimicrobial stewardship. Novel antibiotics are precious resources that must be used judiciously to preserve their effectiveness. Accelerated approval should therefore be linked to appropriate stewardship measures, surveillance, and post-marketing monitoring.

Zaynich symbolises the maturation of India's life-sciences ecosystem and demonstrates that Indian innovation can address global health challenges at the highest level. By ensuring rapid, responsible access to such breakthroughs, India can reinforce its emergence not only as the world's pharmacy but also as one of its innovation engines.

The writer is senior scientist and programme officer, AMR, ICMR

Data upgrade: New WPI, PPIs on June 15

Siddharth Upasani
New Delhi, June 2

THE COMMERCE ministry, on June 15, will release the new Wholesale Price Index (WPI) series with 2022-23 as the base year, starting with data for May as well as a back-series from April 2023 onwards.

However, this new year series will in all likelihood be discontinued after five years and the output Producer Price Index (PPI) will become the main measure of non-retail inflation. While CPI inflation is used by the Reserve Bank of India (RBI) to decide interest rates, the WPI is crucial too and used in price escalation clauses in the supply of raw materials, machinery, and construction work. For example, in long-term sales and purchase contracts, WPI is used by companies as an indexing tool to adjust terms to account for changes in prices in the future. The Ministry of Finance's Department of Expenditure will issue a circular on the same, Praveen Mahto, Principal Economic Adviser in the commerce ministry's Department for Promotion of Industry and

• Items to weights: How the WPI is changing

	WPI-2011/12 series		WPI-2022/23 series	
	No. of items	Weight	No. of items	Weight
Primary Articles items	115	22.62%	129	22.76%
Fuel & Power items	18	13.15%	25	14.11%
Manufactured items	564	64.23%	803	63.13%
TOTAL ITEMS	697	100%	957	100%

SOURCE: MINISTRY OF COMMERCE & INDUSTRY

Internal Trade (DPIIT), said on Tuesday.

“The purpose of the circular would be to tell users of WPI that the government has decided we'll be transitioning from WPI to PPI in a period of 5 years. So now, when you enter into any fresh contract which is of long-term nature and will go beyond 2031, then you have to start using PPI,” Mahto said. He did not specify when the Department of Expenditure will issue the aforementioned circular.

Statistical overhaul continues

The new WPI series as well as the release of an output PPI continues the government's

overhaul of India's official statistics. Earlier this year, the Ministry of Statistics and Programme Implementation (MoSPI) not only updated the base years for CPI and GDP data but also improved the methods used to calculate these key economic indicators.

On Monday, MoSPI released its revised Index of Industrial Production (IIP) series, with 2022-23 as the base year. MoSPI is also working on the services sector counterpart of the IIP.

Output, input PPIs

Along with the new WPI series, the commerce ministry will, on June 15, also release three different types of Producer Price Indices. These in-

clude the monthly output PPI — for May as well as a back-series starting from April 2023 — and a monthly input PPI for the manufacturing sector on an experimental basis starting with March. It is expected the input PPI trial will last for around a couple of years, during which the quality of data is examined and feedback from the users of data and other stakeholders are discussed.

The output PPI helps measure the prices received by producers and excludes net tax as well as trade and transport margins. To begin with, the output PPI will contain 125 items. Once the WPI is discontinued, the items in the output PPI will be disaggregated and rise to around 1,500. Meanwhile, input PPI measures the prices paid by producers to buy inputs, which includes trade and transport margin. PPIs also cover services, while the WPI basket only contains goods.

According to officials, while the output PPI is similar to the WPI, the input PPI is closer to CPI. Economists and organisations such as the International Monetary Fund have repeatedly called on the govern-

ment to develop PPIs to appropriately 'deflate' nominal GDP into real GDP.

So far, MoSPI has been using a combination of WPI and CPI to adjust GDP in current prices to compute the real GDP, although the new GDP series is expected to use the output PPI once the new index is found to be stable and reliable. To be sure, the government has repeatedly said India's WPI with 2011-12 as the base year is not too different from an output PPI.

While both WPI and output PPI are calculated using prices received by producers, the latter is seen as being more consistent with the national accounts framework and aligned with global best practices.

Finally, a Services Producer Price Index will also be released on June 15 for seven services: banking, securities transaction, management of pension funds, insurance, railways, air (passenger) and telecom. The services PPI will be on a quarterly basis and the first number will be for January-March 2026.

Like the WPI, all the three varieties of the PPI will have 2022-23 as the base year.

India, UK discuss ways to resolve CETA deadlock

New Delhi: A delegation of UK trade officials, led by Secretary of State for Business and Trade Peter Kyle met Commerce Minister Piyush Goyal amid new irritants emerging in the path of operationalising the Comprehensive Economic and Trade Agreement (CETA) between the two countries.

“Had great conversations on charting the next phase of India-UK economic engagement, advancing shared business priorities, and further strengthening our robust and forward-looking partnership,” Goyal who led the Indian delegation posted on 'X'.

The operationalisation of CETA as been delayed because the UK introduced surprise

steel duties. Otherwise, both sides expected CETA to enter into force by April. Indian officials had earlier said both countries are trying to find a way around the steel measures.

On 19th March the UK announced a new steel trade measure. From 1 July 2026, the UK government decided to limit tariff-free steel imports, reducing overall quota volumes by 60% compared to the steel safeguard measure. Any imports above these levels will then face a 50% tariff. The measure will apply to imports of steel products that can also be made in the UK. These measures were announced by the UK government on 19th March this year. FE

• TECH

How Nvidia chip reshapes AI for personal computing



Soumyarendra Barik

NVIDIA, THE major semiconductor company powering the AI boom with its graphics processing units (GPUs), has announced a new “superchip” for personal computers, as the hardware giant looks to directly take aim at the likes of Apple and Intel.

Nvidia has partnered with Microsoft to launch the new chip, called the Nvidia RTX Spark, and it will power computers made by the likes of Dell, Asus, and HP. With the new chip, Nvidia — known for its dominance in AI infrastructure so far — is pushing beyond its traditional graphics cards into integrated chips that power the whole PC.

Nvidia is unrivalled in the AI space because of its powerful GPUs — the demand for which has skyrocketed — and has pushed once dominant companies such as Intel to the fringes. Today, Nvidia is the biggest chipmaker in the world, with a market cap of over \$5 trillion.

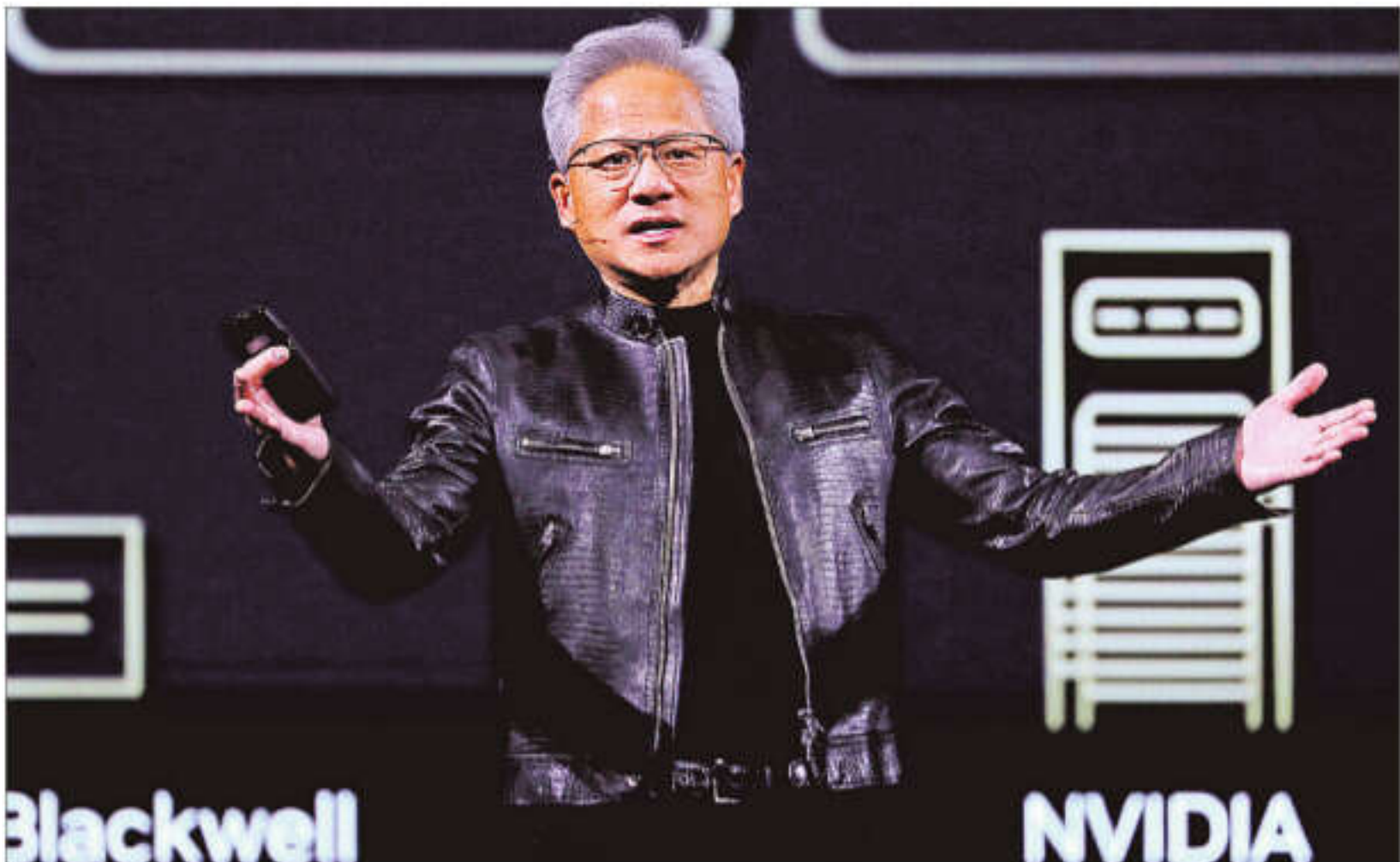
In 2020, Apple shook the world with its own line of chips with the launch of Apple Silicon, a move that also saw it break away from its long-term partnership with Intel, which had supplied chips for its computers since 2005. Intel, the legacy chipmaker for personal computers, has meanwhile struggled to keep pace with the AI boom and has lost market share to the likes of AMD and Apple.

RTX Spark

The Nvidia RTX Spark is a purpose-built superchip for Windows AI laptops and compact desktops. It fuses a 20-core Arm central processing unit (CPU) and a Blackwell RTX GPU (6,144 CUDA cores) via NVLink-C2C. It delivers 1 petaFLOP of AI performance and supports up to 128GB of unified memory, enabling it to run 120-billion parameter local AI models.

In simple terms, all this just means that it packs enough computing and memory power into a single chip to run advanced AI models locally on a personal computer. Here’s what these acronyms mean:

CPU is a computer’s brain-like component that performs calculations, executes instructions, and manages the flow of data



Nvidia CEO Jensen Huang in Taipei on Tuesday. AP

across the system.

GPU is a specialised electronic circuit designed to rapidly manipulate memory and perform complex mathematical calculations at incredibly high speeds. A CPU processes tasks sequentially, whereas a GPU can execute many calculations simultaneously since it is designed for parallel processing.

CUDA CORE is a specialised parallel processing unit inside Nvidia graphics cards.

NVLink-C2C is Nvidia’s chip-to-chip interconnection technology that allows CPUs and GPUs to communicate and share data with each other.

FLOPS, or Floating-Point Operations per Second, is a commonly used metric to measure processing power and efficiency. Floating-point operations are a certain kind of mathematical calculation using real numbers with fractional parts.

UNIFIED MEMORY refers to a computing architecture where all processors — be it CPU, GPU, or specialised AI processors — share a single pool of memory.

The chip, built on Taiwan Semiconductor Manufacturing Company’s 3-nanometre architecture, is expected to power more than 30 laptops and 10 desktops. The key pitch that Nvidia is making with the new chip is that it will power Windows PCs “purpose-built for personal agents”.

“The PC is being reinvented,” said Jensen Huang, founder and CEO of Nvidia.

Behind Nvidia’s dominance

Intel, the legacy chipmaker for personal computers, has struggled to keep pace with the AI boom.

● Nvidia is unrivalled in the AI space because of its powerful GPUs, the demand for which has skyrocketed.

Nvidia is known for dominance in AI infrastructure. Its push towards integrated ‘superchips’ could set off a new chip war with Intel and Apple

global PC shipments. Computers from Acer and Gigabyte will also soon launch with these new chips.

Nvidia said that laptops powered by the RTX Spark will boast “all-day battery life”, and added that Adobe was remaking its Photoshop and Premiere software from the ground up for the chips to deliver twice as fast AI and graphics performance compared to current alternatives.

The new chip wars

Intel dominated the computer chip market for several decades, but started losing ground to competitors such as AMD, Nvidia, and Qualcomm as it failed to adapt to changing customer trends towards mobile and AI. Intel made chips that powered devices running both Microsoft and Macintosh, but was handed a major blow in 2020 when Apple announced its own line of semiconductor chips and announced it would phase out its Intel-powered computers.

Apple’s current generation of Silicon, the M5 line, is widely considered to be the leading consumer laptop processor chip, equipped to run AI apps locally on a device. Apple has since cornered a nearly 15% market share in the PC market, which has come entirely at the expense of Intel.

Nvidia now poses a new threat to the fledgling chipmaker. Having already established itself as one of the most influential companies behind the AI boom through its expansive AI infrastructure across hardware and software, the semiconductor giant is now coming after Intel’s key business, Windows PCs, where it continues to hold a majority market share, especially at the budget end.

“It could pressure Intel and AMD in client CPU in the long-term. The caveat is that the Windows-on-Arm software-compatibility challenge is real and unresolved, so first-generation volume hinges on Microsoft’s ecosystem work, not the silicon,” Moorhead said.

The wide consensus on Intel chips has been that they failed to pivot from its traditional CPUs to GPUs, bet on the wrong internal AI architectures, and ignored software ecosystems. These strategic missteps, paired with manufacturing delays, allowed Nvidia to capture a near-monopoly on AI hardware.

Intel is working to launch its own AI chip that uses cheaper memory and cooling technology than rival offerings from Nvidia and AMD by the end of this year, the *Financial Times* had reported.

• LEGAL

Parentage over privacy: Why SC upheld DNA test in paternity case

Amaal Sheikh
New Delhi, June 2

THE SUPREME Court recently dismissed a challenge to orders that directed a man to undergo a DNA test in a civil suit filed by a person claiming to be his biological son and, in doing so, reiterated an understanding of when the courts can and cannot direct such tests.

The bench of Justices Sanjay Karol and N Kotiswar Singh held that “as far as the right of privacy is concerned, we are balancing, in this case CP’s privacy with [alleged son’s] desire for closure on a question that has loomed large on his life throughout”.

The claim arose from a civil suit filed by the respondent who attained majority, which sought a declaration of paternity and a share in the property of the father, who had denied the claim of his parentage since 1999.

The bench noted that three questions determine whether a DNA test can be directed: if paternity is “directly in issue”, if there is “any other evidence-on-record” capable of substituting for it, and if ordering the test is “in the best interest of the parties and/or justice”.

The court held that the alleged father, CP, had denied paternity consistently for over two decades, and there was no other evidence on record to answer the question. Weighing his right to privacy against the alleged person’s interest in establishing parentage and pursuing inheritance rights, the court thus upheld the DNA testing of CP to determine paternity.

The legal framework

In paternity disputes, Section 112 of The Indian Evidence Act (now Section 116 of the Bharatiya Sakshya Adhiniyam) is invoked, which states that any child that is born during a valid marriage or within 280 days since the dissolution of the marriage is the legitimate child of the husband and “unless it can be shown that the parties to the marriage had no access to each other at any time when he could have been begotten”.

BALANCE OF INTERESTS

● In ‘Ivan Rathinam v. Milan Joseph’ (2025), the top court held that courts must protect the parties’ rights to privacy and dignity by evaluating whether the social stigma from one of them being declared ‘illegitimate’ would cause them disproportionate harm, as against the child’s legitimate interest in knowing their biological father.

Previous SC cases

There is no provision expressly authorising courts to order DNA testing. The jurisprudence emerges on a case-by-case basis and is framed through precedent.

In 1993, the Supreme Court in *Goutam Kundu v. State of West Bengal* held that a DNA test “cannot be ordered as a matter of course” by the courts and that applications that seek DNA testing “in order to have roving inquiry” cannot be entertained. It also observed that “no one can be compelled to give sample of blood for analysis”.

In *Dipanwita Roy v. Ronobroto Roy* (2014), the court permitted DNA tests where it is necessary to resolve the dispute, but also noted that “if the direction to hold such a test can be avoided it should be avoided. The reason is that... the legitimacy of a child should not be put to peril.”

In *Aparna Ajinkya Firodia vs Ajinkya Arun Firodia* (2023), the bench held that parties must first present evidence, after which a DNA test may be ordered when the court finds it “impossible to draw an inference based on such evidence”. The court held that “children have the right not to have their legitimacy questioned frivolously before a Court of Law. This is an essential attribute of the right to privacy. Courts are therefore required to acknowledge that children are not to be regarded like material objects, and be subjected to forensic/DNA testing, particularly when they are not parties to the divorce proceeding.”

The bench of Justices Sanjay Karol and N Kotiswar Singh had, in *Nikhat Parveen v. Rafique* (2026), reiterated that “the common thread that has run through all these judgments is a well-placed hesitation to order or to give an imprimatur to orders directing DNA test to be conducted”.

• ECONOMY

FDs over savings account: What’s behind changing preference

George Mathew
Mumbai, June 2

THE COMPOSITION of bank deposits in India has undergone a significant shift over the past five years, with savers increasingly moving their money from low-yield savings accounts to higher-return term deposits, according to the Reserve Bank of India’s (RBI) latest data.

The RBI said that the share of savings deposits in aggregate bank deposits declined sharply from 34.6% in March 2022 to 28.7% in March 2026, reflecting changing preferences among depositors in a rising interest rate environment. In contrast, the share of term deposits rose from 55.2% to 61.6% during the same period, indicating that customers were increasingly willing to lock in funds for fixed tenures in exchange for better returns, the RBI’s ‘Annual Basic Statistical Return on Deposits’ report says.

Low interest rates

The trend of declining savings bank rates gathered momentum during 2025-26 as banks continued to offer attractive rates on fixed deposits to mobilise resources and support credit growth. As a result, overall

deposit growth strengthened across the banking system. Banks now offer low interest rates on savings bank accounts. SBI, the largest bank, offers just 2.5% interest on savings accounts. Savings rates have fallen from around 6-7% in the last ten years.

SBI, on the other hand, offers 6.25% on one-year FDs and 6.45% on two-year deposits. HDFC Bank also offers 6.25% on one-year FDs and 2.5% on savings bank accounts. ICICI also offers 2.5% on savings accounts. Savings account rates declined as the RBI slashed the repo rate — the rate at which it lends money to commercial banks — from 6.50% to 5.25% since January 2025.

Purchasing power erodes

When the savings bank deposit rate is below retail inflation, the real return on savings is negative. In simple terms, this means the purchasing power of money in a savings account is eroding over time.

The current savings bank rates of banks are nearly 100 basis points lower than the April retail inflation level of 3.48%. One basis point is one-hundredth of a percentage point.

Demand deposits (savings and current account) of the banking sector were Rs 31.65

Medium-term fixed deposits

● The share of term deposits with an original maturity of one to three years rose from 50.4% in March 2022 to 69.8% in March 2026

● During the same period, the share of deposits with maturities of up to one year declined sharply to 8.8% from 16.7% during the same period.

● The trend suggests that customers sought to lock in favourable interest rates for longer periods.

lakh crore and term deposits Rs 225.23 lakh crore as of May 15, 2026, as per RBI data. Current accounts don’t offer any interest rate.

Savings account deposits provide customers with easy access to their money, allowing withdrawals at any time without penalties or loss of principal. This high degree of liquidity makes them the preferred choice for households to meet day-to-day expenses and maintain funds. For banks, savings deposits have long served as a stable and low-cost source of funding, since the interest rates paid on these accounts are substantially lower than those offered on fixed or term deposits. Consequently, savings deposits help banks mobilise funds at a relatively lower cost while ensuring depositors retain flexibility over their savings.

The RBI data indicates that while households continue to anchor India’s deposit base, savers are increasingly favouring fixed deposits over traditional savings accounts, reshaping the liability profile of banks and strengthening the role of term deposits in the financial system.

Households largest source

Households remained the single largest source of bank deposits despite a modest

decline in their share. Deposits from the household sector accounted for 59.3% of total deposits at the end of March 2026, the RBI report says. However, households are increasingly turning to mutual funds and equities as preferred investment avenues, attracted by the prospect of higher returns compared to traditional savings instruments like FDs. The contribution of other sectors increased. The share of deposits from the non-financial sector rose to 18.5% from 17.7% a year earlier, while deposits from financial corporations increased to 7.8% from 6.8% over the same period.

Larger FDs dominate

A look at term deposits shows that larger deposits continued to dominate. Deposits of Rs 1 crore and above accounted for 46.3% of total term deposits as of March 2026. Within this category, deposits of Rs 5 crore and above alone constituted 34.8%, underscoring the growing importance of high-value depositors in banks’ funding base. At the other end of the spectrum, deposits of up to Rs 5 lakh accounted for 17.8% of total term deposits, according to the RBI report.

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• HEALTH

Don’t take that puff: ‘Herbal’ cigarettes are not healthy alternatives to tobacco

Ritu Sharma
Ahmedabad, June 2

IN RECENT years, several supposedly “healthy” alternatives to cigarettes have been growing in popularity. Among these products are tobacco-free “herbal” cigarettes that market themselves as “safer”, “natural” alternatives that can help you with everything from depression to anxiety to stress.

At first sight, this safety claim would appear to make sense. After all, the most harmful part of conventional cigarettes is the nicotine in its tobacco. So wouldn’t a product made with herbal ingredients be less harmful? A recent study, however, has busted the claim that tobacco-free means risk-free.

Here’s a look at what herbal cigarettes are, what the study found about their claims of safety, and how they are falling through the regulatory cracks in India.

What are herbal cigarettes?

Herbal cigarettes, unlike regular ones, do not use tobacco as fillers. They instead

use herbs and dried flowers — such as clove, basil, mint and cinnamon — that impart different flavours.

And while regular cigarettes use paper as wrappers, herbal cigarettes use *tendu* (ebony) leaves — just like *bidis*, India’s most widely consumed smoking product. Herbal cigarettes are generally longer than a *bidhi* but shorter and thinner than a cigar.

What did the study find?

The study, titled “The lure of ‘Healthier Smoke’”: Comparative physical, chemical, and oxidative potential characterization of emissions from herbal and tobacco cigarettes”, was published on May 17 in the *Journal of Hazardous Materials*, a peer-reviewed international journal.

Alok Kumar Thakur, the study’s lead author who is currently pursuing post-doctoral research on air quality emissions at Colorado State University, told *The Indian Express* that several of the herbal cigarettes they tested were marketed with claims such as relieving cough, improving sleep

or easing anxiety. However, studies on their emissions and toxicological impacts have been limited, he pointed out.

This study compared emissions from two of India’s highest selling tobacco brands and four popular herbal varieties containing combinations of basil, clove, cinnamon, mint, green tea, water lily and chamomile.

It found that emissions from herbal cigarettes were comparable to or exceeded those from tobacco cigarettes on nearly every metric measured. “That finding is important because many consumers associate nicotine-free products with reduced harm,” said co-author Vishal Verma, an Associate Professor of Environmental Engineering in the Department of Civil and Environmental Engineering at the University of Illinois Urbana-Champaign.

How did the study measure impact?

The researchers combusted each cigarette inside a sealed, two-chamber rig designed to replicate human inhalation. They then funnelled these emissions into instru-

ments and collected samples, whose oxidative potential they quantified as a proxy for toxicity. Oxidative potential refers to the capacity of a product to generate reactive oxygen species. These are aggressive molecules that drive inflammation, lung tissue remodelling and the vascular changes behind heart disease.

The particulate matter from herbal cigarettes recorded significantly higher oxidative potential than that from tobacco cigarettes. Leaf-wrapped herbal variants turned out to be the most hazardous. Their oxidative potential was roughly 49% higher than paper-wrapped versions.

Chemical analysis also revealed that one herbal cigarette, filled with basil, had the highest lead concentration, despite being marketed as “chemical-free with 100% natural filler for a healthy lifestyle”.

The researchers found that herbal smoke emitted sub-500-nanometer particles — less than one-hundredth the width of a human hair — at approximately 20% higher concentrations in herbal smoke

than in tobacco smoke. These fine particles are increasingly linked to cardiovascular and respiratory disease.

Aside from the health impact, the study also found that the combustion produces pollutants such as particulate matter, carbon monoxide and hydrocarbons.

Dr Harshal Ramesh Salve, Centre for Community Medicine at AIIMS Delhi, told *The Indian Express* that herbal cigarettes are as hazardous to health as conventional ones, especially for youngsters who are their major targets. “From a public health aspect, all sorts of cigarettes are harmful. While tobacco cigarettes always have nicotine content, the other forms of e-cigarettes or herbal cigarettes, which are promoted as an alternative to traditional cigarettes, might develop carbon particles which are equally harmful,” he said.

The regulatory gaps

Owing to the limited scientific evidence on long-term health impacts, herbal cigarettes often fall into regulatory grey areas.